

LASTMAN

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job.buthedld.excelatit.

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guns,for he wasdman steeped in violence, He-was. always pre.
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LAST MAN STANDING 3

gating the hallowed piece of earth that stretched between the
Slaves safely and - eomfert of yellow and i moment of teeth-green
could-be quite eventful, "Cam promises authority- Web said- the
word to hit nscf, 1 was just away of fagking for the okay to gutt,
down people if necessary and making lv sound. like you were
merely giving permission from your, bus to cut a few bucks off
the drive of. a used car Railio, - sqqucteh was broken again as TOC
said, "TOC to all units. You have compromised authority. ant per-
mission to move to yellow"

Thank you 'sowerynech, TOC. Web edged closer to the cargo doors

of the Suburban- Hewas point and Roger McCallam had the rear.
Tint Davis' Was the bid tier arid Biner- was the team leader. Big
. Cal Plummer and the other two assaulters, Lou Patterson and
Damy Garcia, stood. ready with MP. 5 machine gun. and flash
bangs in .45-caliber pistols, and their cal in deimcandss.. AS soon
as the doors opened, they should fan out in a rolling mass laa-
ing forth threats from all directions. They would move. to first, the
heel, kalvesbeni. to absorb the impact as they had 10 fire weapons
face mask- shtunk. his field of vision. to a maddest view in Barca his
Miniature Broadway for the coming. Feal- lit tint
aided cketor Tancysuit required Hand signals would- stiffen from
now, on. When bullets were flying at you! you tended to get a bit of
cotton mouth anyway. Web never talked much at work

He watched as Danny. Gatch crossed himself
every time And Web "gaid what Re. always said when
crossed himself before the Chevy, door pop

out too far away from ground. dg
right up to their final destination
thei

and other, bulky ob-,
jects conveniently placed the road 19 L.
Radio squeal broke again as - snipers from X-Ray Team. called in.
There were men in the alley. up ahead, X-Ray reported, but

of the group Web was hunting. At least, the snipers didn't dl

Wro-by-four explosive..yet the logistics here? were a ite

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LASTMANSTANTING s-

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BandaundBoydiddCallafter-Web,somethingaboutadmiring Web'srifle.andwanting.to-buysit,He'd.giyehimasweetdeal,.he YelledalterWeb,andthensaid"he t-ShuotWeliandeveryone-else deadwithit.HACHATWebglami dtathe rooltaps, where hekirow meribersof- Whiskey Teativand-XYRaywere-iii-heir. forwaud.firing positions with rounds seatedani-tethalbeadsdrawn-on-thebrain ers.-wereWeb's'besl-ftl nds, pprodchied they, rork,becarise

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LASTMANSTANDING 5

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bellshouklersrattygymahortshungdewnpast TilsQrute crackand
atankshittodelapsidedaerossfils tmsculastorse.Healso hadan
attdadeseveraluileslong-tiding-onhisfeaturtes, Thekindthat
saidl,Vanronaster,toughorandwillauliveyou.Web hadlo-adeilt,
though,theGuycarriedthe rag-lookwell,

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Boywereloopedoutof thelrminds-andthatnorefthedruggles
werecarryingRUNSor cellphonesthat could.beusedto.callup
thetargetandwarnthem..BaridanadBoydidhave.a knife,yet
kniveshad-aio.chanceagaliistKevlaratid sabmachineguns. The
teansletHiimkeepILButasCharlicTeam movedon, GalPluinmeer
ranwiththentbackward,hig.MP-5tdinedonthe youngback-
alteryentreprenenr,justincase.

BandannaBoydidcallafterWeb,sometbingabout adniiring
Web'srifleandwantingto.buyIt.He givehimasweetdeal, he
yelledafterWeb,andthen saidHe'dstioutWebandtveryoneclse
deadwithit.HA-HALWebglancedtotherooftops, whereheknew
inembetsufWhiskey-TeamaridX-Raywercin their fonvardfiring
positionswitlt rounds-seated-and-lethal ds-dtawi ontlicbrain.
stemsofthis.gaggle.oflosers.Thesnipe voreWeli'sbedtliends.
Heunderstoodexactlyhowthey appradthedthuiZ,work,because
foryearshelrad-beeriOrigofthem.

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pissed-alf-watermaccasins ciawlingoverhimi,Or-clsebeen
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andthe.mercurywasstill failing,Andstil! the-boyhadis'shirt
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LASTMANSTANDING

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been-duutethistoylong.adwasa'titaheilofaumetesOT
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musdesWebhadcnarmausleverageinhaslongaommyatdstrang
Angers,andtherewasdeceptivepowermbisnauallytread
shauiders,Andhewasdyfarthefastestraaneathetcamandalso
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Fewouldrakespendquickness.andstaminanwerbutgingmusttes
anyday,Sulerstoredhroughmmscleasasilyasthey.didtanYer
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odbome.impastthemgtahght.mesninghadlyanyatalloneel-
caostwouldi'rmoticetheoldcaiecthemavrbdafcheekandthe
mgofmansplaatedboneandskin.Tnulyremarkable,
alibadS2id.AllexceptWeb,thotis,

Attheendofthealestheysiippedomatmore,areanhinghaw
ALWetvseibowwasTeddyRinet.ThroeghhisvorekasMonmu

was2tvreinsoadashugpermussenfomiwetogreenheTorhs
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dovzWetbeldtheSRYSwaithe nebimdandfoutarbiscustoms-

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Neer -

LASTMANSTANDING 7

around, the protrusion of ribs. As a tree grows, bark cords save a
wound. A knight's ashtray across the boy's forehead. A puckered,
dilated hole on the child's chest. Check was the unmnivakable tag of
a butler, Wol-knew.

ePaniidobell!?-said the child in a weary voice, and then he
laughed on more decently, cackled. The hey's swords and that
langlirong like cymbals. In Web's stead, and he had no idea why
Nisskit was actually Ungling the hadsvenhopeless kids. With this
he tore. They were everywhere around Rere, and yet something was
gaitag. on-dn Web's heel that he couldn't quite figure. Maybe he'd
be doing this too long, and was nitite a hell of a time to start
thinking that?

Web's sliger hovered near this little trigger atid he moved far-
ther in front with grace. It did seem as if he tried to rid himself of
the boy's image. Though Very learned himself, a nil. lacking showy.
nituscles, Web hid his enormous leverage in his long arms, and strong

fingers, and there was deceptive power in his naturally broad

shoulders. And he was by far the fastest man on the team and also
possessed great endurance. Web could millerelays all day.
Few would take speed, quickness and stamina over bulging muscles
any day. Bullet store through muscle as they did fat. Yet
the lead couldn't hurt you if it couldn't hurt you,
Most people would describe Web. London, with his broad shoul-
ders and standing six-foot-two, a big man. Usually, though, peo-
ple focused on the condition of the left side of his face, or what
remained of it. Web had to grudgingly admit that it was amazing,
the reconstruction they could do these days with destroyed flesh
and bone. In just the right light, meaning hardly. Any way, one al-
most wouldn't notice the old crater, the new tissue of cheek and the
delicate grafting of transplanted bone and skin. Truly remarkable,

all had said. Al except Web, that
At the onid of the alley. they stopped-ancemore, all cgouching low,
At Web selbow was. Teddy Riner Througly his wirelgss Motorola

Kariemic, Riner communieated with. TOC, telling them that Charlie.
avas. at yellow and asking permi

fontomove. to. green the "crisis
site-of. the target, whieh here jvas. simply-afaney term for the front
doot Web held the SR73 with-one hand and telt for-his custom-

pavipBALDACC

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aetoTOSThecomaia!words,Charlie'atgrienTOC
wedanreveg,agateeys2d,et Sant byl have contrcl
TeatfneamzpccteedWeb,becousewhothehellreailyhascom-
meiZanypetheyEP
oftheusmdvan.Altetheccomtoflro,le perswexid25-
Ee dfire,gnd3tesyof.3635tanigsmultanconslywas
evdaon.Tremtheteeachoe bivworfoseTOCsaid
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pAVIDBALDACCE"

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web Could raceJotheduorDavies would betront and
a oh ings charge.Assaulters wouldholdtheir-flashbang
centerfay!

iM afetieswouldbeoff,

x fnweakhand,Subguns. swould p

grentadesloosely Hed dtayofftriggers-untiltitswas'thhretoKilt
andstcady tinge themechasiicalsafetieson-thecontrolbox \

Davieswould-resto ecordattach thebreaching.charge,

nfcheckthedetonato atta eOICal dae

ee dhopingtofi e.Rinerwouldcom-

lonkingforproblemsandhoping9-Nt Deyyt

ee . talwords,Charli.at-green,"TOC

municatetoTOCthe.ammorta OP -

wouldanswer,asitalways h,-"Standby.1-Rave-control

ThatlineahyaysrankledWe yliothe-hellreallyhadcon-
troldoingwhiattheydid?

DiringhisenilrecarcerWebliadneverNeardTOCfeachthe-end
of'theCountdawn.After-thie.countof-two,,thesnipers-woulden-
gagetargetsandfireanda-bevyof.308sfiring simultaneously was
-2tadInoisye,ThenThe.breachcharge-wouldblow.beforeTOCsaid
"oneand-thalhigh-decibethhurricanesyould.drown, outevenyour. i
aghts,-tnfact,Lyou-e dTOCfinishthecountdown i
you-were'indeep trouble,-because that-meantthe.breachcharge i
had Fatledt 19gooffAndthatwas't a-louyway.tostart.the- \

workday eee oo

Whienthe cxplosive.blew thedoor,Weband. his'team-woul
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named,since-theflash".svealldblie, " se Puy.
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anymore-luckeddogs,1 inprotecied-eardrum.Iftheytahinto
Mbors,thesewould yiekUquickly.ei hein
Fohteknock-knock OfDavies's shotes quickly.cithertothejin-
lochedleke.astripof tire-rubber Sun-oFto-a-slap-chargethat

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alYOunevertectepeeostaReSeandtake.the
er.teally thougin aboutwas dying.

LASTMANSTARDING

That took a lot of energy away from the details of the mission. And away from the bedrock of justice and discipline from the things that have and do not become a part of what made you, who you are.

According to reliable sources at the time, they were going to be contained in the entire range of a major drug operation headquarters in the capital city. It included the potential that tonight were accountants and the accountants, the witnesses for the government. Web and Nismen could get them out alive. That way the Fed could go after the guys criminally and civilly from a number of fronts. Even drug lords feared an IRS. It was a frontal assault, because he thought Kingpin pay taxes to Uncle Sam. That was why Web's team had been called. They specialized in killing the folks who needed it, but they also were damn good at keeping people alive. At least until these folks put their hands on the bible, testified and sent some of them away for a very long time.

When TOC came back on, the count down would be in five, four, three, two..." -

Web opened his eyes, collected himself. He was ready, -Pillse at sixty-four. Web just knew. Okay. Boyss pay dirt's dead ahead. Let's go take it, TOC came through his headset once more and gave the okay. To move to the front door.

And that's precisely when Web-London froze. His team burst out from the overhead light for green, the crisis site, and Web didn't. It was as though his arms and legs were no longer part of his body. The sensation of when you've fallen asleep with a limb under your body and wake up to find all the circulation has vacated that extremity. It didn't seem to be fear or a gut away murmur. Web had been doing this too long. And yet he could only watch as Charlie Team raced on. The courtyard had been identified as the last major danger zone prior to the crisis site, and the team picked up its pace even more, looking everywhere for the slightest hint of coining resistance. Not a single one of them seemed to notice that Web was it out with them. With sweat pouring off him, every muscle training against whatever was holding him down, Web pained slowly to rise and take a few faltering steps forward. His feet and arms seemingly encased in

lead,hisbadyonfireandhisheadbursting, hestaggeredonwarda

cea .

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LASTMANSTANDING 3

That took a mule Uite and eneniy away from the details of the mission, oh away from the bedecked lustinians and disciplines honed from doing the sotal-thing over an taver until he became a part of Fwwhat had you nywie

According to people, the nudging they were doing, it remained the one Anarchy of a major dry operation headl-quanted in the capital city. Aneluded in the paccati! haul tonight qwere agcu UNTanis and bean counters, wable wittinesses lur the gove erment-HFWelsanathismen-could get Hiemeut alive. Thadway Hte

Feds could go all the way to criminally and aivilly frothy in a room of -oreg fronus, Even drug tords deared-an 1RS full frontal assault, because as Lea

seldom did King inspire payaxes-fo Uneleame Thnts as why Webs ream had been called up. They specialized in killing folks who needed f1, but they also were damn good at keeping a pov ple alive. At feast until these folks put the hands on the Bible, testified and sent some greater evil away for a very long time

When TOC came back on, the countdown would begin "Five."

toun, Ubtce, TWO 5

Welyopental his eyes collected himself, he was ready, Pulse at sixty-four. Web just know.. Okay boys, pyro dirt's do a head.-Lil's go take it, TOC-came through his head set once and gave her okay to move to the front door, .

And there precisely When Web. London froze. The team burst out from the cover heading for green, the crisis site, and Web didn't. It was as though his arms and legs were no longer a part of his body, the sensation of when you've fallen asleep with a limb under your body and wake up to find all the circulation has vacated that extremity didn't seem any bear-ox run away. Aervess Web had been. do itg UES

ton Jong And Yet. he could only watch as Charlie Jean raced across the courtyard. He identified-as the Jast major danger as a priest

thecrisis-s1 spickediapitscpa-ce-even-nlbte lati,

cies
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pitmore, reached the courtyard, and then he dropped flat on his face as his team pulled away, from him. on his

In .10 seconds Charlie Team running hard, the tar.
get in their sights, seemingly just begging them to come and
take the piece of it. The team was five seconds from impact. Those next few
seconds would change Web London's life forever, and a few

He glanced up

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SOMTWNPEOSODgnIninegthoy

sgbining,this
raweatheDellymochxetherhy Bothy

feddyRihersvent-downfirstOFthewvo secondsIttookhimto
fall,thamaritiadbeen-dead.forone.ofthem thieother side
Cal-Plummerfelltothe ground likehe'd been pole-axed by' agiant.
as Web watclied helplessly, p.anddownn, the. compact lineshieavy
ordnanceimp randthenflesh,aridthenthere.was
nothingelse.It didn't scem.rightforgood-men.to diesoquietly.
Beforetheguns-started. firing.. Web-hadfatlenon hisrifleand.it
was wedged underhim.He-couldbarely breatlie.hisKevlar-and
weapons seemed crushed a. i aphr agm. Therewassuiff
in tt-waspartofTeddy.Riner,
throv-offfromthemonster.rou athadblown.aholethe.size
ofamanspalmthroughhisbodyatmorapdsentpartofRiner fly-
ingbacktowhereWeblay,deadlastofCharlicTeartand, ironically
enough,theonlyonestill living.

Webstlllfelt. paralyzed, Honeofhisiihbs- responding tapleas
fromhisbrain.tomo .Hatthe-sufferedastrokeat-age.thirty-
seven?' Then suddenly the sdunids.ofgunlirescemedtoclearhis
head,the feelingfinally.returned.to-his.arms. and legs-andhe
managedtonipdif-hismask-androll.onhis back. He.exhaleda
gushoffoul-alr andscreamed1iirelief,NowWebwas.staring
straightupattheskyHesawspeaisoflightning,thoughhe
couldnthear.eventhe belly ramblesof-theabunderoverthe

-puntise.

Hehad.apowerlul-If-Insqne urge.tofit np hishandintethe
-qnackstrensibavebhin, pyrhaps toconfirmthe presence of-thiebul-

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a a,asthoaghhewereayoungsteTtold-not-to1,4
jersracingpashOagthen,ofcourse.thinkofnathingof
porstoveand9Y he swntobisbelt,undidthelatchonaside5y
vsteadhie ieacheet thermal umager.Onthe,blackestmoi.44
and-pulled on vatireworld inyvisibleto theunaided eve,.265
wuld pick oPaeatsigiatlUC thatburnedinjustabour everyth
an.oathe-cOre -unableto'seeUacr.evertWiththeTLWebc,

roel vhe vapartralls thrownoffbythenet-ofbutiers.
casily-sense hee fim.Web-also.observedthatthe.densegut
ping acre qwo'separate directionsthetenement uit
akCOda-dilapidacedstructure.totheimmediateright
dead ane ivhisThattheTatterbuilding. and.sawnothing
saepellse,Ad theii.Web-observedsommethingthatmade
boly.1enseevenmore.The muzzle flashes.were cruplingat
sametime.atachofthe'shattered.windows.'Theymovedac
the-apertures,sioppitdfora.fewseconds,andthenmovedt
actoss,'as-thegunbartels-he'couldnot.seeyet.knes.were!
comipletedtheircontrotiedfiringarc.
Asthe-gunfire.began-anew,Webrolldoveronhis-belly

Staredattheorigenaltargetbuildingthroughlms-imager.Here
tive was.adine.ofwindowsin.thelower levelofthe-target..

Veb-couldnowmakeoutthelong
hrough-theTTthe-silhoucttes'of
al-moltenhotfromtheamiuy
ima outiine,.though,came'ty
, hai 1in'thevicinity,Web'sim.
hime sire looking-at someKin
now-Knew.thathisteaimHadt

netny PULLiNg-asingle.man.ats
hrapects behind-and tother
Mtlingallaround,
ed thedeflections

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BrareeTELts

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2 hewereaYOuNRSertoldnottotoye

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jotstave.aB w lon tohisbelt, undidthelatchonaside prch

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anentire world Invisible iF eu ath YeZetGing
igi thatbumedinfastabonr everything.
inanthe core vasunabiyt'seethemeven. whththeTI,Web could
tlouoglie-88 amt rrailg.thirown-offbythemet.ofbulletszjp,
casilysease the a Webalso.observed-thatthe-Censeguntire
ping.dcross above, w separate directionstheteneinent building
veascming-o ia idaredstructuretotheimmediate-right-He
dead shear i mat thelatter-buildingsandsawnathing.but
he whyAndthe Webobservedsometitingtiatmade-his
eee riove.The.muzzleflasheswereerupting.otthe
sametimiieateachofthe-shatteredwindows, They.moved aeyOss
tlieapetiures.stoppedfor.a few. seconds, anil then movedback
aeross,dsthe-gunharrelshe-couldnot.see yetknewwerethere
completedtheircontrolledfiring.arc. . .

As.the.gurifirebegan-anew,Web.rolledoveronhisbellyarid
stated.attheoriginaltargetbulldingthroughhistimager.-Hete-too
therewas4lineofwindowsiitheliwerleVel.ofthetarget.And
the,same-muzzle'fisheswereoecurringwiththeexact-samesyn-
chronizedareof Movement.Webcouldnow-makeoutthelongbar-
iels.ofthemaching-gunszThroughtheTTthessilliouertesof-the
euns.werebrlekredthe,metalmiokenhot-fromthe-amountof
than they re Spay Nohonian outline,though, cameupon

ecmal,aidIfanytiianBadbeehinthe-vicinity,Web"simag
would-havenatledhim,Hewasfor'sureleol eeesget
eeusto-conialledthing-postHe ie looking-a'some-kind-of
Theslugsricochistedoffthebri ie puling.asitiglemanatrisk.
OthieWebsfedy biisotshe isle Usbehind.and to'theright
sh tihg-allaround,likehard-

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LASTMANSTANDING 13

Alrectfiit, forthemachineguriswere.almost certainly dolingout
i '50-caliberordnance, witheachroundastongaso butierknife
. and-probablyarmor-piercingtev. Webcould-gauge allthis, front

thesupersoniccracking-soind inadebyteguns.and thesigna-
tureniuzzleMash. Aindthe vapor trallofta50-caliber.was also
\ sometliingpretty Mama unforgettable, Infactyou felthe snap
befareyoueveriheard theround4traisedevery-haironyour
body..asLightningdidright beloreitsfatalblow.

Weliscreamedoutthe-namesofhis teamiitesone-byoncNo
answerNomovement, Nomoans, nobody twitches'toshowthat
lifewassdiloutthere somewhere.AndStillWebyelled-out their
namesagainandagain, like-same insanisoll-call, Everywhere-
around-hingarbagecansexplodid, glass burstwalls.ofbrickwere
being-efodedasif tludgeoningriverswere-carvingcanyo s.This-
I wasNormanuly'Beach,ointore-aptly. Pickett'sCliarge, and"Web
hadjusttost hisentireaimy.Alley-vermiiNedthe jJaughiter, That
i conitiyardwasa8clearvol suchtrodentyasitever had-been.No city
i inspectorhad.ever'done.as.gooda jobas-rhythmic 50ealiberord-
\

nanicedidthatnight, .

"Webdidn'twanttodid, buteverytime'helookedat whatwasleft
ofhis.team, apartof- fim-wantedtojolrthem.The familyfought
i anddiedtogether, tbeld someieappealTorWeb, Heacuallyfelthis
lichaleaptoetcrityyel something, strongertook"
i boldand ayedhuinkered.down.To digwast0-lose.To give-up
was ioteVeryoneperishinvain.

Wherethehellwere.X-Ray and-Whiskey?WhyWeren'tthey faste
ropitigtotherescue? The.shipersionthebulldings overlookirigthe
courtyard'couldn'tcon down without gettingrippedapart
though,yettherewere SI nthe'roofsofthe-buildings

nipers

alongthealleyCharlie hadcome through.Theycouldropedown.
ButwouldTOCgivethentthegFeen Vight?Maybenot, ifTOE
didn'LknowWhalwasgoingon. andHow.could.they?-Webdidn't
even.know whatthe heitwaygoiig.on.and hewas-right.inthe

middleofit.Yethe Zouldi'texactlyhangaroundWaitingforTOC.

tomakeup their mind untiba'strayrowndmadeira-cleansweep of
Web'steam

aypteety,

ey
pyre

paseo
, peeeeaye
yhiw neve vowel

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re va rte eal aud it ia ine
idle a rat tue. aed can fi it thn nite
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HotreeduadHICeatTOe aemny
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BpeentodhadeverHGnc0s quad fob.

caeteHHELADHBHT
eveteueeEsvaraEntWALEvery ulmehe lyokeda

Ceyreaganan-abpacyefairwWarteel.UOJOIn remThE
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bese fiveanedioheesiqetee otoslly yersomething arrose
cewtpevtayeattivath,seedLaeHt todiewastaJase TogiveUll
ceasfoefepeverpanigPCHAETIEait.
sygeceHeeWattleiteeSelaye ainfWhiskey? whywent
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atweakness.fromhispsyche.

ametbing. niclostsWeb

vdaingsametbing.Hisbonen

tedtabe cone from ItsshoulderVelcropatch.He
se tedTnto it,SHRfourteersttoTOC,WRfour-
le .

a edttothebackupfrequency
teenteTOCNoresponse soso tiothing.He looked.atthe
andtheatoa general ths frantwas-smastiedfrom-wherehie
radie-andisspirits ie redfopwatduntltDe reachedCalPlum-
nadfallenantWebsill iedt0 rabPlumnier'stwo-way.radio,
mers-bouy.Whenhel the pulledltbacksAricocheronlysa
scmetlifnghitWeb's,handandhe i ofLWebcountedfiveAngers
direethit.would"ye taken hand wantto fight,to live!If

here.andtheintenspainymadebimwant oe

tare oihe?reasonsharito'destroywhoeverhad-done.this,al-
dmeinthiscareerWebwonderedfftheoppositionhenowfaced
Wasactuallybetter.tlianhe was. oo, .

Webknewthatifhe.stoppedthinkinghe-still.mightleapup,fir-
ingatnothingthatcouldbe'killed..Sohe.focused"on-thetactical
scenaria.Hewasinacarefullyconfineddeath.zone,automaticfir-
ing.arcyon'twwosides,foriing.aninely-degree-angle-ofdestruction
andprovidingno uiman-agentthatcouldbe stopped?Okay,that
Wasthefieldsttuation.Nowrwhatthe hellwashe.supposedtodo.
aboutit?Whatchaprer-was.thatin.the manual?Theonethatread,
"Vou'tescrewed"?Gad,thesouindswere deaferiing.He-couldn't
Whe ed hisheart pounding. His-breath camejn-short, gasps.
caulrmanyfaeeteta08XROV?ndRowet?They
WeteUained.to-gun downB yetwhatreally, couldthey-do?They.
taike.-Hescreamedout,Thy mmentargetsatHothlong-and.dese

Chintuckedhardtohischest,WebYOUshioott"
8eUittlehay,bhe shirtless one Vebstartedj Surpriseas.hesaw

fomthechunkof concrete..Hay
SoncTete..Harids

. neat the edgeor the corner,along
yhad-cometrom, lhe-movedout

ayer afpanicsetl
niall tobanistth

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LASTMAN.STANDING 15 r

i and al most-at-the courtyard. Maybe-he was intending to come net help. Maybe he was waiting for the gun fire to stop so he could , strl p the bodies of any valuables, sragging U heir weapons for later rs f. resale Gn the streets, Maybe-bewas fusi U ate out cuniots, Web - aH din't know. or redlly care. -

The guns stopped fir tag and just like that i berewas quiet. The boy took another step farvard. Webscreained at hin, He froze, obviously not expecting. the ie ad 19 yell at the Hy ing, Web linched tip his harid, called-to hin etn, keep back, but the gun fire started again and drowned ont the endal'his warning, Web slithered on his belly under the hail of fire, shouthig at-the boy with every twist and thrust afhs. peilvis, Stay back! Get back!"

The kid didn't flinctic Web-kepl his gaz don Him, which was dl-Reult when you'weredouble-timing on yaurgul, aftaid that if you raised your head another.centimetryou would no longer have a head, The boy finally did what Web thought he-would do zHe started to.fall back sWebciawled faster. The.kid turned to.ran.and Web yelled at him to stop, Shockingly, he did.

Web was-almost to the edge of.the alley,-He was-going-to try and thnethig just! right, for. there was now.anew elcment of danger for the child.-During the last Pause in the firing eb had heard syn-chronized footsteps. ani shouts in the Be i Web thought it must be everybody? Hoteland the'snipers, and the reserve unit that TOG always kept back for emergencies-Well.if this didn't qualify-as.an emergency, nothing ever swould. Ves,d they were husiling to the rescue, or.so-they thought. What they were really doing though jvas running blind agithy nO reliable intelligence. i The problem was the ki j 'the-boy kne actly what.and who th ing the earth'and deducing.from that the local herds.The boy was feeling trapped and for goad.reason knew that for the alley kid to be dund 'people' like Web.Avas a death Sentence-here, The piowers.that bewould j just. assume lie was a traitor and deposite his body in the.Woods as his reward.

The child twitched, looked-behind him-eventas Web picked up his pace.Web lost.half his equipment.whippinig-along the.rdu ghass

phaitlikethat,-atwo-hundred-poundserpentorspeed.Webcouthd

LiKe ascout sniff.
ionOfgreat buifalo

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LASTMANSTANDING 18.

and alive at the courtyard, Maybe he was intending to come
help Maybe he was walling for the gun till to stop - strbecould-
stop the bodies of any valuables, shagging the weapons for later
resate on the streets. Maybe he was fustl into outcours. Web
didn't know really cate

The guns stopped firm. and just like Wat there was quiet, The

boy took another step on the road. Web set aimed at him He froze, ob-
viously not expecting the dead to yell at this living. Web inched up
his hand. called to 'hins to keep back, but the gun fire started again
and drew the crowd - the crowd of 1 is warning, Web slithered to his belly
tader the hail of fire, - slis in tag at the bay with every twist and
thrust of his pelvis. Stay back! - Get back!"

the kid. didn't flinch Web kept his gaze on him, which was dif-
ficult when you were double timing on your gut, a raid that if you
rayed your head another centimeter you would no longer have a
head. The boy finally did what Web thought he would do He
started to fall back Web crawled faster. The Aid curbed the rune and
Web yelled at him to stop. Shack! -

Web was almost at the edge of the Hey He Was going to you and

this is just right, for the He was new to danger far
the child. During the last pause in the firing Web had heard, syn-
chronized footsteps and shouts in the distance. They were coming.
Web thought it must be every body's Hotel. and the snipers, and the
reset with that TOE always kept back for emergent well, if this
didn't qualify as an emergency, nothing ever would. Yes, they were
hustling to the edge, or go. U thought. What the hell,
doing though was turning ill with not reliable intelligence.

The problem was meat and toa, Web could tell
the boy knew. "Ukeas scout isn't
ing. the can the preat buffalo
herds. The season, Wely
knew 1 of 5 of ? b. was
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DAVID-BALDACCI

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toodcanmrit nglikeacouplethonsandwaspswere,

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Thebodyarmor wassodaimnheavynow,hisbody nies

hrustoffhisarmsandlegs. Webcouldhavedroppedhi,
wad usefor.it.No.hewouldneverletgu-of lhe

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owe Ser wihatthekidwasgoingto-do,Retrcat-cut-off,hewas
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going tog ri g sthecourty dandthen disappear ina
A 'olorHI,Taceacrass thecourtyar ine
re oftlie puildings onthefar side.The boy. couldheartheL ullers
ane

aswweltasWebcould,.Yethecouldnotsev theHinesoffire,Hecontd

ante m.AndyetWeb knew thebaywas-aboutto-tr,
ay ad Hud auto theblocks,and Webleapt offhis belly at
thelastpossiblesecond.sothatthe iwounel right atthe lringe of
safery.in.a.colldlonWebwould.wintentimesoul of ten.Thechilld
kickedat.Weby-hisknotty,fistsstruckhlinraboutthe-facandchest
dgWeb's.Jong.armswrappedaroundid-him,Webwent-backfarther
intothe.alicy,carryingthekid.Kevlar'wascoteasyonthehands
and'theboy-fina ystoppedpunchingandlookedatWeb,Tain't
donathitig,Let mie.gol?
SYou-rungutthere-youdie!"Web-yelledoverthegunfire,He

held up his bloody harid. I'm wearing it, body armor and I can't survive out there. Those bullets will cut you in half.
The boy calmed a little. He studied Web's side farther away from the courtyard. At least, he thought, he could talk without shouting. From his odd position, the bullet hit the boy's cheek. "You're dead," Web said. The boy tumbled and jerked away from Kee. Of Web's grip, he was, up, ferret-like, before Web had turned to run. Back down the alley, the boy ran. "Web said, pour some water on you. Go to the kid, stop and hide. Forth they'll blow you away. Seemed like a focus on Web, they heard the first time his eyes truly "They're dead?" he asked. Peered beyond the courtyard, in answer Web .
"Look at the hatch on the door. That's the intimidating weapon,

patina in shadow
You'll see and keep down, Web said

Upped the big rifle from his shoulder. The boy

turned back to the

on him, 'breaking

Wes. a

WebcontLince-Stunstedy

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LASTMANSTANDING i7.

courlyand.Sirenswhereeverywhereuaw.Thecavalrywascoming.
1oolate,asthecavalryalwaysdid.Thesmartestthingtodo.would
benothing.Yetthatjustwasn'tgoingtocutW,Webhadajobte
linish.He tipped apiceeofpaperfromthenotebookhe carriedon
bis beh andscribbtedaquicknote,Hethen pulledoffthecaphe
woreunderhishelmet"Here."he-sald-tothekid.Walk,.dan't
tun,backdownnthie-atley.Hold-uip-thiscapantlgivethisnotetothe
mencomingthis-way."Theboytook-theltems,hislong-lingers
curled.arouudtheclothofthe.capsandthefoldedpaper.Web
pulled-hisflacegunfromitspouch, and loaded in.aRare. Whent
fire,yougo,WalkiWeb sald agaiz n'tmn,"

The boy looked down ay tt ng idea if he could

the fundamentals ofeducationthat other kids. tookfor- ranted.
What's.yourname?".Webasked.Theboyncededto-becalmnow,
Nervous? people. mede mistakes. And Web knew the-chargingmen

Okay, Kevine'm-Web..Youd6what'I Say. and you'llbeokay.You
canwrustme,"he-said,.and thenfeltguiltier-still. Web. pointedthe
flare gum.tothe stelonked. t Kevin nodded seassuringly and, then

would Don'trun," Web yelled. He turned back to the court-
yardand'slidhisthermati imager ontothe-ri te" 'sPicatinnyrail
Jockeditintoplace,
The.red-coldredNare-bioodiedthe,sky-andin.his.mindWebsaw
the-assaultersand-snipers,-stop-and-. considerthis.development
Thatwould-give-tic-boy-time.toreachtiem. Kevin-would-notdie!
not tonight, anyway. When-the next panse in thewave.offirecame
Welsburst outfromth
assuued a Prone fiting.

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ftheieaponslikeparachutists.ftong

Toe'sBelly,Whenthefast sholwasfired,Wehdoubletovy,

vauektngLispreetonsalt Hecivas.sohot hethoughthemight-spon.

racouslycombust,,Then thecloudsapenedandtherain-caine

doanhatk.Hefookedover dndsawamarmor-coatedassaniiay

crutionstycdgeInte-the, courtyanlWebtriedtosvaveto.him,tu

hisarmwouldn'tfallmy theoujghyftusthumglimplybyhisside.

Websurveyed.the- shaneredbodiesofhisteam,hisItends

spwadoverthestickpaventent.Thenbe sank-to.hiy-knees.Hewas

aliveandhedidu'treally.want.tobe.ThelastchingWebLondonre-

membered-Gontthar'uightwas,watchingareps-ofhis'sweatfall
into-thic-bloud-thitedpaals.ateain-

paviD MALDACCI

18 ahimtodratva beadonthe heatedoutlines-of'themachy
awe! Shae -ewhathe wantedtobit.The SR75.roared-aitdone Nn
ee gunrnest. aheranother exploded..Web rammedin anothe,
foenty-tound mag,4 aimedtherille andpulledthetrigger,andfou,
moremachine gunswere finally'silenced. TheJastgun est-was
stilts when webcrawled forward and lobbeda CONCUSsion
grensadtainte Itstthroat. Andthentherewa ilence-untilWeb emp.
tiedBithof his455.althe now-silent windowopenings,ejected
cartridges tumbling.out-ofthe.weapons like parachutists froma
plane'sbelly. When-theJastshotwas fired,Webdoubled. over,
suckingin precious.ait Hle'wassobothe thought hem ghtspon-
tancously, combust.

Then the cloudsopenedand the raiitcame
downhard,He- looked

overandsawan armor-coated,assaulter

-cautlously.cdgeint. te courtyard. -Webtriedto,wave.to him but
4

his.arm wouldnt followthroughyitjust hunglimply by hisside,
-Web-su cdthe" shattered" bodiesofhisteam,-hisfriends

spreadovertheslick pavement.Thenhe-sankt
ohiskneesHewas.
aliveandhedidn'treallywant.tobe.Theastthing Web Londonre.

menibetedforit.that-nightw
ight..waswatchin,
intotheblocd-tintedpoolsofrain. g drops'ofhis.sweatFal

Re Cove 'was a very-big man endowed with great physical strength. And so remarkable a feat that he had further honed over many years of work. He was an FBI undercover agent and had been on for nearly seventeen years. He had infiltrated Latin drug gangs in LA, - Hi 5 Mexico border and heavy weight Europeans in south Florida. Most of his missions had been starling and, at times, nail biting successes. - He was currently armed with a .40 semiautomatic chambering hollow-point that would collapse to small pancakes when they en-

for life or death, at a time he was executed for his terrible life was in serious trouble and he also realized he was who could get himself out of it.

Cove crouched low in the car and watched as the group of men climbed in their vehicles and headed out. As soon as they passed, Cove rose, waited a bit and then followed them. He pulled his ski cap tighter over his newly shorn head, the dreadlocks all gone, and about time to go, he had decided. The cars stopped up ahead and

Cove did too. When he saw the group of men emerge from the ve-

hicles, Cove pulled a camera from his backpack and clicked away. He put away the Nikon, pulled out a pair of night binoculars and

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DAVIDBALDACCI

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djstan .
one go of one last deep breath and took a fast.
ns ife thus far as the group disappeared into
forward. rcel On cove had been a bigger, faster version of Won
building. college us All-American from Oklahoma, every NEL
ter Paytons comment of cash and other perks at him, The,
eam Wasa vu shared ACE it both knees during a Treakish
wvore, Uat SE bine had reduced him from a supernary.
spAe pick to 4 man with merely no
ranteed number-one pick 1 to 4 mal ne Ay-Normal
ecw no longer excited NEL coaches, Millions of potential
ddallar shad disappeared instantly and the only way of life he had
wet known 'had vanished along with them. He had moped for a
lear g fore excuses and pity, and his life had spi-
thad nowhere else to go, and then he had
cena-divine intervention, he had always
licieved, saving his miserable, 'self-pitying carcass from oblivion,
With her help, -he had straightened himself out and fulfilled a se-
qev dream as of his 6 be. a real-life G-man's
-He had bounced here and there in the Bureau. It was a time
when opportunities for black men were still severely limited. Cove
had found himself pushed toward drug undercover work, because
Hissup had bluntly informed him that most of the bad
dudes "Were people of his color- You can walk the walk and talk
on a wie a Patton 9 they had said. And he- Goudn't
beating. Raatally i hk Was dangerous enough to never
And he put away more looks. ine easily tolerated being bored.
away' 10' the if-enitire carcass, and eenthan Most-agents pul.
thetrus money mak Tio theni se Were big fish, che planners
Msnert from a Bi nickel

7 ith rand-dime street walkers one
beautiful children and he is thinking Y
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LAST-MAN STANDING 21

messed up badly been snonk ereed lilt the mast greewagent there was, His pridewashurt and his anger was molren, And these ev-
cnth member of the shattered team de eply inurigned Cove., The
man had survived when he should have been dead too and appar-
ently nobody knew why, though it was early in the game yet, Cove
wanted to look at it the eye and say, Ho, y come you're still
preathiny? He didn't have Wweb Londgn's file and he didn't see him-
self getting it any time soon, Yeuly, Cove was FBI, but yeah, every-
one was no doubt thinking he had turned traitor. Undercover
agents were supposed to be right to the edges weren't they?
They were supposedly all beat cases right? What a thankless job.
He'd been doing all these years, but Lbat was okay because he had
done it for himself, nobody else.

'The.. cars pulled into the lang dxive- and Cove "stay 1,, took
some more pictures and then turned around. That was appar-

ently it for tonight. He led back to the only place he could be
safe Tight now, and it wasn't home.. As he rounded a curve and
sped up, a pair of headlights seemed to appear out of nowhere
and settled in behind him. That wasn't good, not on a road like
this, . Atten from his fellow man was not something Cove ever

sought or encouraged. He turned so did the car., Okay, this was,

serious.. He sped up again.. So did the tail. Cove reached down to
his belt holster, pulled out his pistol and made sure the safety
was off.

He glanced in the rearview mirror to see if he could tell how
many folks he was dealing with. It was too dark for that, no street-
lights on this way. The first bullet blew out his right tire, the
second bullet hit his left rear, As he fought to keep control of the car a
truck pulled out from a side road and hit him broadside.. If his win-
dow had been up Cove's head would have gone right through it.
The truck had a snowplow on its front end, though it was not win-
ter time. The truck accelerated and Gove's Scar was pushed J in front

of it, He felt his car about to roll and then the truck fished his

Sedan over a guardrail that had been placed there principally to

protect vehicles from plummeting down the steep slope. The car-the
curve of road was built around, The car's smashed into the ditch

-and then rolled, both doors popping open as he, sedan continued

LASTMAN STANDING at
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ne1lorhimself,nobodyelse a ds
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ve-righytannyjand-itwasn't.Home.Ashe roundedaCUTNET
vilatp.apairol heaulighits'seemedtoapprat outa sa fike
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is,Anentianframtibsfellow manwasi somethingVOre was,

nuythTat-encouraged. He-tumedso did-thecar Okay

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muau.Hesped-upagain.So did-the tail.Cove reagent cafel
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DAVID BALDACCI

22 nally Janding in a heap at the rocky bottom of

i rites.

Pave stopped and on a mangrove out,
earl and he looked down, He saw the fire, vile
explosion as fuel vapor met flames and then ran back
nessed the explosion 'vehicle' skidded up gravel leaving these engines.
to his car. The earl I Coves slowly rose from the spot where he lied
A steady he i. the driver's door had been ripped open by the
ee it he ground. He had lost his gun and I felt like
first impact was a cracked, but he was alive. Tielooked downy,
on "ie rhs car" and then backup at where the men who
na ied i kill him had raced off. Gove stood on shaky legs and

started slowly making his way backup.

Its earthieelings fi

the slope and
he car that
to the twisted

lan

Woauched nis syouided hand even. ashi is head scemed primed
to explode, it was like he had taken three quick slugs of straight
tequila and was about to relax them. The hospital room was
empty. There was an armed man outside to make sure nothing
happened to Web nothing else anyway.

Web had been tying here all day and into the night thinking,

about what had happened, and he was no closer to any answers
than when they first brought him here. Web's commiander had al-
ready been in, along with several members of Hotel and some of
Sitipers from Whiskey and RRay, They had said little, all of
I, gony, their disbelief that Some-
Pe hed to them, And in the if eyes

NS. the issue of what had happened

glikethiig could-have
Web Could-sese, theIrsuspici
tohiinoutthere,
"VON-SoryDebble wt
widow, Hesedite, Web'said-10the imageofTeddyRiner's
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LASTMANSTANDING 23

believablethat-1s?"hecatled Onttothe
sHlentagain

"We'regoingtogetthemWeby"

ThevoiceStarttedWeb,forhehadheardnootie-eater thereon,
ButolCoutsea-Voicecamiewitha body,WebIncheituponhlsbed
unllhesaywlheoutline-ofdhemanthere. Percy'Batessatdown
tnachalrvextt6Web.Theamatstudiedthe linoletimooras
thoughttEwere-amapthatwould gulde-himto-aplace-thatheld
alltheanswers.

ItwasSaidthatPercyBateshadnot changedajotintwenty-five
years.Theman-hadn'tgainedorlost.apoundonhstrimBve-ten
trame.Hishairwascharcoal-blackwithout acreepofwhiteandwas'
combedthesameway.aswlienhefirstwalkedintotheEBIfresti
fromtheAcademy,1twas.asthoughhehadbeen flash-frozen,and
this Wasremarkableina-liveofwork.that.tendedto age.people
wellaheadoftheirtimeHehadbecome'alegendof.sortsatthe
Bureau.Hehadyreakedhavocondrug'operatiois-at-the-Tex-Mex
borderandthen-goneontoraisehell.on.theWestCoast-intheLA
FieldOffice,Hehadrisen-througlithe-raniks quickly.andwas'cur-
renilyone.ofthetoppeopleatthe WashitigtonFieldOffice,or
"WFO,"asit-was.cailed,Hehadexperienceinallthe majorBureau
divisionsandthemanknewhowall the-pieces.fittogether.

Bates,whowentbyPerce,wasusuallysoft-spoken.Yebtheman
could-crumple-asubdrdinatewith-alookthatmade oneeelun-
worthy-.tobe.eccupyingasquare-footofspiec.-Hecouldeitherte

-your."best-allyor-yourworst enemy,MaybeUialshowa aman
lurmedoutaftergrowingup-with.aname likePerey.

Webhadbeenonthie-endof'some-oftheclassicBatestirades

-before,whenhehadbeenunderthe.miansdirectcommandtn
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learned to be a good agent, - Yet Bates did play favorites from time to time and, like everyone else, sometimes went searching for scapegoats to pin blame upon when things went to hell. Thus, Web did not accept the mians' statements right now at face value. Nor did he accept the subdued tone as a token of peace and good will, Yet the night Web had lost half his face in the lurch of combat, Bates had been one of the first people by his bedside, and

Web stood, before falling

LAST-MANSTANDING v3

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DAVID BALDACCI

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LASTMANSTANDING 128

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LASTMANSTANDING 25

"This will be a median nightmare, you know what, " said one of them. " I had the red J's, in fact, Bates stuck a piece of gum in his mouth. substitute for the

Winston, he had given up for the fifth time now and counting.

"The need to suck a wall of a journal is a high on my priority list," he said.

You have to keep them informed, Perce. Why don't they have a stand-start making a hub. There's already been a still on the Internet you wouldn't believe, that this massacre is either the apocalyptic re-enactment of Jesus or something to do with a

Chinese trade conspiracy. I mean, where do they get this crap? It's driving the media and the people mad."

"I can't believe anybody would have the guts to do this to us," said another man, who had grown gray and plump in the service of his country, Bates knew this articulate agent had not seen anything other than the top-6 of his government desk in more than a decade but liked to act as though he had. Not the Colombians, the Chinese or even the Russians could have the guts to attack - like that." Bates glanced at the man. "It's us against them, is it? Remember? We try to cram it down their throats all the time. You think they don't want to return the favor? ,

But my God, Perce, think about a squad of four men. On our home turf, diguantly, . . .

Perce looked at him and saw an elephant without tusks, just about ready to drop and die and become dinner. For the jungle carnivores, I didn't realize we had laid claim to that part of D.C." said Bates. He had last slept the day before yesterday and was now really starting to feel it, "In fact, I was under the impression that Chat was their home turf and we were the visiting team."

You know what I mean. What could Rave prompted this sort of attack?" .

Shit, I don't know, maybe because we try so damn hard to pull

the plug on their billion-dollar-a-day drug pipeline and it's starting to really piss them off, ya idiot! As he said this, Bates backed the man into a corner and then decided the guy was far too harmless to be worth a suspension.

They just slaughtered
the old fellow blustered in-

DAVIDBALDACCI

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ness. Then, in the funny way of big organizations, Winters had received promotion after promotion for his incompetence, until he had reached the top of WFO. Maybe the Burcaut was just unwilling to admit that he messed up and believed that promoting from the ranks of the leaders to the top of the Waco fiasco was a strong message to the world that they Bureau considered itself blameless. Eventually, many heads had rolled because of the flameout of David Koresh in Texas, but Buck Winters's head was still firmly attached to his shoulders. For Percy Bates, Buck Winters represented much that was wrong with the FBI.

Bates leaned against the wall, crossed his arms and chewed his Wrigley's - so hard his teeth hurt. He was certain that old Buck would be running off to confer with the FBI director, the attorney

general, probably, even the President. "Well, for him, so long as they-

all kept out of Percy Bates's way.

The group of men slithered away singly and in pairs until just

Bates and the uniformed guard remained. Finally Bates moved off too, hands in his pockets, gazed at nothing. On the way out he spit his gum into the trash can. "Assholes and idiots," he said. "Assholes and idiots."